

St. Joseph's Anglo-Chinese School
F.5 English Language
Grammar - Lesson 4: Cleft sentences

Cleft sentences

Part 1: Proofreading quiz

Each sentence contains TWO errors: one in a noun form (nominalisation) and one in subject-verb agreement. Proofread the sentences.

1. The school's decide to ban mobile phones in class has reduced distraction, which make lessons easier for teachers.
2. Many parents worry about young people's rely on smartphones, because these devices distracts them from their homework.
3. The improve of online security has protected customers, but some banks still refuses to warn them about scams.
4. Students should show aware of the risks of sharing personal information online, because careless posts spreads quickly among their classmates.
5. The government's refuse to control social media companies has led to a rise in online scams, which worry many parents.

Teacher's answers

Item	Correction (fix both errors)
1	The school's decision to ban mobile phones in class has reduced distraction, which makes lessons easier for teachers. (decide → decision — a noun is needed after 'the school's'; make → makes — 'which' refers to the whole idea of reduced distraction.)
2	Many parents worry about young people's reliance on smartphones, because these devices distract them from their homework. (rely → reliance — the possessive needs a noun; distracts → distract — 'these devices' is plural.)
3	The improvement of online security has protected customers, but some banks still refuse to warn them about scams. (improve → improvement — 'the ... of' needs a noun; refuses → refuse — 'some banks' is plural.)
4	Students should show awareness of the risks of sharing personal information online, because careless posts spread quickly among their classmates. (aware → awareness — 'show' needs a noun; spreads → spread — 'careless posts' is plural.)
5	The government's refusal to control social media companies has led to a rise in online scams, which worries many parents. (refuse → refusal — the

	possessive needs a noun; worry → worries — ‘which’ refers to the whole rise in online scams.)
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Part 2: Building a cleft sentence

Complete each cleft sentence with ONE word (it / is / was / that / who / what / until / when).

Sentence	Missing word
1. ___ is peer pressure that pushes teenagers to join in online bullying.	It
2. It ___ the fear of being left out that pushes teenagers to join in.	is
3. It was the school’s slow response ___ allowed the bullying to continue.	that
4. ___ drives teenagers to join in online bullying is the fear of being left out.	What
5. It is teachers ___ first notice how quickly cruel comments spread.	who
6. All the school needs to do ___ provide a safe place to report abuse.	is
7. ___ many parents fail to realise is how quickly cruel posts spread.	What
8. It ___ the lack of clear rules that allowed the rumours to spread.	was
9. It was not ___ a student left the school that the bullying was taken seriously.	until
10. What worries counsellors most ___ the speed at which cruel posts travel.	is
11. It is the victims of online bullying ___ often suffer in silence.	who
12. ___ is not the phone itself, but the endless notifications, that distract students.	It
13. All it takes ___ five minutes of checking before you share a post.	is
14. It was only ___ the school posted the facts that the rumours stopped.	when
15. ___ struck the teachers most was how quickly the story spread across the year.	What
16. It is careless sharing, rather than social media itself, ___ spreads rumours so fast.	that
17. What the panel recommends ___ a clearer policy on reporting abuse.	is
18. It is the school’s silence ___ allows online bullying to continue.	that
19. ___ matters most is how quickly a school responds when a victim reports abuse.	What

20. It is one trusted adult, more than any new policy, ___ makes the biggest difference to a victim.	that
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Teacher's note: after 'It is / It was', use 'that' for things and 'who' for people; 'which' is possible for things but less common. Accept either word from students in items 3, 5, 11, 16, 18 and 20.

Part 3: Cleft sentences in formal writing

A cleft sentence takes one idea and puts it into two parts, so that the most important information stands alone: **Peer pressure causes online bullying** becomes **It is peer pressure that causes online bullying** or **What causes online bullying is peer pressure**. The word order is broken on purpose, so the emphasis lands exactly where you want it. In formal writing, one or two clefts show the marker that you can control sentence patterns beyond the ordinary subject-verb order, and they can also carry an idea from one sentence into the next.

Example 1: It-cleft - focusing on the cause

Plain:	People post cruel comments because they are anonymous.
More formal:	It is anonymity that encourages people to post cruel comments.

It is anonymity that encourages people to post cruel comments. Behind a screen, nobody has to see the person they are hurting, so the usual checks of a real conversation disappear. Asking students to use their own names on the school forum would remove that cover entirely.

Example 2: It-cleft - setting up a contrast

Plain:	Many people blame violent games, but the silence of bystanders does the real damage.
More formal:	While many people blame violent games, it is the silence of bystanders that does the real damage.

While many people blame violent games, it is the silence of bystanders that does the real damage. A cruel post can stay online for days because nobody bothers to report it. Teaching students to speak up matters more than banning one more game.

Example 3: Wh-cleft - presenting a recommendation

Plain:	The school should make it easier for victims to report bullying.
More formal:	What the school must do is make it easier for victims to

	report bullying.
What the school must do is make it easier for victims to report bullying. One anonymous form on the school website would take an afternoon to set up. Once students know that a report will be read, the silence that protects bullies begins to disappear.	

Example 4: All-cleft - naming the only thing needed

Plain:	The school only has to post one clear rule about online behaviour.
More formal:	All the school has to do is post one clear rule about online behaviour.
All the school has to do is post one clear rule about online behaviour. A single sentence in the student handbook would tell everyone what is expected of them. Such a small step would make it far easier for victims to report what happens to them.	

Clefts as paragraph openers

Clefts are also useful at the start of a paragraph, an article or a speech: they decide what the reader notices first. Put the it-cleft in your thesis statement, the wh-cleft in your recommendation, and the all-cleft in your closing line.

Plain:	Social media affects teenagers' self-esteem very strongly.
Cleft opener (What ... is ...):	What many adults fail to realise is how strongly social media affects teenagers' self-esteem.
Plain:	Teenagers only need one adult who will listen without judging them.
Cleft opener (All ... is ...):	All most teenagers need is one adult who will listen without judging them.

Part 4: Practice sets

Rewrite each simple sentence as a cleft sentence. The sentences are about life online, so keep the register formal. The later sets (4-8) are more challenging.

Example Set 1 (It-cleft - the cause)

Simple sentence:	Teenagers copy the cruel comments of their friends because they are afraid of being left out.
Prompt:	<i>Begin with 'It is the fear of being left out ...'.</i>

Teacher's Answer:	It is the fear of being left out that leads teenagers to copy the cruel comments of their friends.
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Example Set 2 (Wh-cleft - what is needed)

Simple sentence:	Victims of online bullying need an adult they can trust.
Prompt:	<i>Begin with 'What victims of online bullying need ...'.</i>
Teacher's Answer:	What victims of online bullying need is an adult they can trust.

Example Set 3 (It-cleft - the person responsible)

Simple sentence:	School counsellors, not the discipline team, should handle bullying cases.
Prompt:	<i>Begin with 'It is school counsellors ...' and use 'who'.</i>
Teacher's Answer:	It is school counsellors, not the discipline team, who should handle bullying cases.

Example Set 4 (It-cleft - the contrast)

Simple sentence:	Teachers blame social media for the bullying, but the school's slow response makes it worse.
Prompt:	<i>Begin with 'While teachers blame social media for the bullying ...'.</i>
Teacher's Answer:	While teachers blame social media for the bullying, it is the school's slow response that makes it worse.

Example Set 5 (Wh-cleft - the recommendation)

Simple sentence:	The government should make platforms remove cruel posts within 24 hours.
Prompt:	<i>Begin with 'What the government must do ...'.</i>
Teacher's Answer:	What the government must do is make platforms remove cruel posts within 24 hours.

Example Set 6 (All-cleft - the only thing needed)

Simple sentence:	To keep victims safe, the school only has to give them somewhere to go at break time.
Prompt:	<i>Begin with 'All the school needs to do ...'.</i>
Teacher's Answer:	All the school needs to do is give victims somewhere to go at break time.

Example Set 7 (Wh-cleft - the hook)

Simple sentence:	Adults say teenagers should just ignore cruel comments, but that is impossible.
Prompt:	<i>Begin with 'What adults fail to understand ...'.</i>
Teacher's Answer:	What adults fail to understand is that a cruel comment

	can follow a teenager everywhere.
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Example Set 8 (It-cleft - the turning point)

Simple sentence:	The school only understood how serious the bullying was after a student stayed away.
Prompt:	<i>Begin with 'It was not until ...'.</i>
Teacher's Answer:	It was not until a student stayed away that the school understood how serious the bullying was.

Part 5: Writing Task

Instructions:

1. Write ONE paragraph (about 80 words) explaining why online bullying is hard for teenagers to escape, and suggesting ONE thing schools could do to help.

→ Use **ONE cleft sentence** (It is ... that ... / What ... is ... / All ... needs to do is ...).

→ Use a relative clause or an inverted pattern e.g. Not only ... / Never ... / Rarely ...

...

Sample answer 1 (It-cleft) Online bullying is difficult to escape because it follows teenagers home: cruel messages appear on their phones long after the school gates have closed. It is this constant presence that makes even a short comment so damaging, as there is no safe hour in the day. Schools should teach students how to block and report cruel messages, which protects every student in the school. A form teacher could cover the basics in a single lesson, and the advice would last for years.

Sample answer 2 (Wh-cleft) What many victims of online bullying fear most is that adults will simply tell them to switch off their phones. That advice, which is usually meant kindly, leaves them alone with the abuse. Schools should therefore run regular lessons on blocking and reporting cruel messages, and make sure every student knows exactly where to turn for help. Silence, in the end, is a bully's best protection, and a short lesson in form time can begin to break it.

Sample answer 3 (All-cleft) Escaping online bullying is hard because the abuse continues after school, and many victims never tell anyone about it. All schools really need to do is give students one trusted adult and one simple way to report cruel messages. This small change, which costs almost nothing, would help thousands of teenagers currently suffering in silence. Parents have a part to play

as well, because a teenager is far more likely to speak up when someone at home takes the problem seriously.

Each sample uses ONE cleft: Sample 1 an it-cleft (It is ... that ...), Sample 2 a wh-cleft (What ... is ...) and Sample 3 an all-cleft (All ... needs to do is ...). Each sample also contains ONE relative clause ('which' in every case) — point these out to students before they write.